Generating Regime Support in Middle Class Russia: Neo-Soviet vs. Hard-line Conservative Gender/Sexuality Attitudes*

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Abstract

Post-2012 the Putin regime took a conservative shift in which it echoed increasingly retrograde positions towards gender and sexuality in its rhetoric and policy. This article quantifies post-2012 associations between the government and conservative attitudes towards the LGBTQ+ community and women's rights among middle class Russians. It does so in a body of literature that currently lacks multivariate statistical analysis. Results from ordered probit models using data from Wave 7 of the World Values Survey demonstrate that conservative and pseudo-"progressive" attitudes towards women's rights and the LGBTQ+ community are positive predictors of regime support. Hard-line conservative attitudes reflected in Putin's more-extreme rhetoric and policy, such as the 2017 partial decriminalization of domestic violence, are concurrently not associated with regime support. My results suggest that the strategy, identified by Johnson et al. (2021), in which Putin's nationwide speeches seek to generate regime support among middle class Russians by matching neo-Soviet attitudes towards women's rights is effective and is also applicable to attitudes towards the LGBTQ+ community. My results also highlight the absence of an association between hard-line conservative gender/sexuality positions and government support. This may suggest that the Putin regime's adoption of such positions in rhetoric and policy is meant to please subsets of influential elites who adhere to traditionalism/ultra conservatism.

Keywords: regime legitimation, gender and sexuality, Vladimir Putin, ordered probit regression, social survey data

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Introduction

On the 2013 annual television special *Direct Line with Vladimir Putin*, broadcast by all major Russian television stations, the Russian president decried the West for its acceptance of LGBTQ+ people, who he characterized as pedophiles:

> "You are indeed correct that during my last trip [to Holland] a lot of discussion time was dedicated to the rights of sexual minorities... But, you, see they have their own standards... if in Holland a court allowed the activities of an organization involved in the spread of pedophilia, then why must we adopt these standards?" (Sperling et al., 2022).

Scholars identify Putin's explicitly homophobic rhetoric to be part of a conservative shift following a large anti-regime protest movement in 2011/2012. By focusing on "traditional" views of gender and sexuality as part of the conservative shift, the Putin regime paints itself as a defender of the Russian family while opposing libertine Western immorality (Sperling et al., 2022).[1]

Related sexual/gendered discourse and policies, through which the Putin regime has attempted to legitimize itself and its initiatives since assuming power in 1999, have been the subject of numerous studies, e.g. (Gradskova, 2020; Johnson et al., 2021; Riabov and Riabova, 2014; Sleptcov, 2017; Sperling, 2014). Though such studies suggest the Putin regime's sexuality/gender-based regime legitimation techniques are effective in various ways (and to various extents), the effect of attitudes towards gender/sexuality on regime support have not been quantified using multivariate statistical methodology.[2] In the post-2012 context, the lack of such research may lead to an overstating *or* understating of the efficacy of gender/sexuality rhetoric in generating regime support among middle class Russians.

I use Wave 7 of the World Values Survey to test the the relationship between measures of attitudes towards gender/sexuality and regime support among middle class Russian respondents using a series of ordered probit models. In doing so I seek to answer the following research questions: In what ways has the Putin regime's conservative turn fostered associations between itself and attitudes towards women's rights and the LGBTQ+ community among middle class Russians? To what extent has this strategy been effective in generating support for the regime? How does this inform scholarly understanding of Putin's use of gender/sexuality-based regime legitimation?

[1] Equating the LGBTQ+ community with pedophilia is a common attack used by anti-LGBTQ+ actors in Russia and elsewhere (Sperling et al., 2022).

[2] Social survey data has been used to a limited extent in related contexts. For instance, Magun and Rudnev (2010), Bahry (2016), and Shcherbak (2023) use social survey data to examine conservative sentiment among Russians - though attitudes towards gender/sexuality are not a focus (Bahry, 2010; Magun and Rudnev, 2010; Shcherbak, 2023).

Sexual/Gendered Regime Legitimation in Russia

During the 1990s, the implementation of "shock therapy" and the end of the Soviet-era work assurance policy made the transition to a market economy painful (Gerber and Hout, 1998; Standing, 1997). Russian men were largely confronted with an incapacity to serve as bread-winners which was now considered the main criterion for masculinity. Combined with Russia's loss of superpower status, the nation experienced collective emasculation (Riabov and Riabova, 2014).

Putin's image was accordingly crafted in parallel with an emerging model of Russian masculinity, *muzhik*, which bears no reference to socioeconomic strata while designating status as a "real man." Putin's *muzhik* masculinity thus promotes images of national masculinity that legitimize the regime (Riabov and Riabova, 2014). Moreover, Putin's brand of masculinity - conveyed by photos of the President riding bare-chested on a horse and videos of him insulting male reporters - developed a popular "personality cult" and allow him to establish dominance over other men including potential rivals (Sperling, 2015; Wood, 2016).[3,4] Inherent to Putin's masculinity politics are sexism and homophobia, which strengthen the regime by exacerbating societal divisions and thus underscore the idea that certain people (heterosexual men/autocrats) should rule over others (homosexuals/women/democratic rivals) (Sperling, 2014).

The Putin Regime's Conservative Shift and Traditional Values

During parliamentary elections in December 2011, volunteer election monitors documented election fraud and posted videos on the internet that went viral, sparking large-scale protests in Russia's cities. Residents of Russia's hinterlands largely sided with *muzhik*-Putin who they felt protected their economic interests, and the movement consequently died down by 2012 (Crowley, 2021; Holmes and Krastev, 2013).

Soon after, in August 2012, the prosecution of punk rock group Pussy Riot took the public spotlight. The trial centered around events in February 2012 when Pussy Riot posted a video of its performance in Moscow's Cathedral of Christ the Saviour to the internet and "explained in an interview that it was protesting against the patriarch of the Russian Orthodox Church and calling for the resignation of Putin, whom it considers a 'symbol of the patriarchal mores and sexist bigotry that has plagued our society'" (Riabov and Riabova,

[3]Photo (from 2009 vacation) available here: https://www.nbcnews.com/id/wbna32299822.

[4]Video refers to a 2002 press conference in which a French daily *Le Monde* reporter implied that Russian troops were killing civilians by sowing mines indiscriminately in Chechnya. Putin angrily responded by telling him: "If you are prepared to become the most radical Islamist and are prepared to get circumcised, I invite you to Moscow. We have specialists that deal with this problem" (Traynor, 2002).

2014). Widespread disapproval of Pussy Riot allowed the regime to concurrently flex its coercive power without opposition, solidify its support base among middle class Russians, and build a connection to the Orthodox Church (Smyth and Soboleva, 2014).

In line with the anti-feminist prosecution of Pussy Riot, the Putin regime continued to shift in a conservative direction following the 2011/2012 protest movement (Evans, 2015; Laruelle, 2013). In particular, the regime began to increasingly promote conservative social attitudes towards women and the LGBTQ+ community through the notion of "traditional values" (Andreeva, Drozhashchikh and Nelaeva, 2021; Edenborg, 2018; Gradskova, 2020; Moss, 2017; Sleptcov, 2017).

This shift is embodied in policies such as Putin's 2013 law which "protects" children from being exposed to homosexual "propaganda" as well as the 2017 partial decriminalization of several forms of domestic violence.[5,6] It is also embodied in frequent statements in conferences and interviews. For instance, referencing his 2013 "gay propaganda" law, Putin urged LGBTQ+ attendees at the 2014 Sochi Olympics to "feel relaxed and calm [in Russia], but leave children alone please" (Putin, 2014).

In the backdrop of all of these events, Russia has experienced a shrinking population from 1999 to 2012 and again from 2016 onward. In 2006, Putin boosted child support payments and initiated cash payments of 250,000 rubles to women who chose to have a second child. More recently, proponents of traditional values have advocated for solving Russia's "demographic problem" by increasing the birthrate among ethnic Russians. To this end, abortion and divorce are depicted as anti-family societal ills (du Quenoy and Dubrovskiy, 2018).

Reflecting Gender and Sexuality Attitudes as Regime Legitimation?

Existing scholarship asserts that the Putin regime has embraced (or at least partially embraced) conservatism and traditional values in the post-2012 context. For instance, Moss argues that the Putin regime has fully embraced traditional values, co-opting the oligarchs,

[5]Russia's 2013 anti-gay law "bans the spreading of 'propaganda' of non-traditional sexual relations" among minors. The law in effect makes it illegal to equate straight and gay relationships, as well as the distribution of material on gay rights. It introduces fines for individuals and media groups found guilty of breaking the law, as well as special fines for foreigners" (Elder, 2013).

[6]Concerning the partial decriminalization of domestic violence, "first-time offenders who beat their partners or children... no longer face criminal charges... [A]s long as the beating does not cause serious harm, and as long as it happens no more than once a year, abusers... receive an administrative penalty – either a small fine (the equivalent of around 500 dollars), community service or up to 15 days of detention. The change... means victims themselves... [are] responsible for gathering together evidence and bringing a case forward" (Thomson, 2017).

Orthodox church, state educational system, and media (Moss, 2017). Bluhm and Brand find that the Putin administration has partially adopted traditional values, yet traditional values continue to be "contested within the elite" (Brand and Bluhm, 2018).

Scholarship on the extent to which the Russian middle class buys into conservative gender/sexuality politics (and whether this legitimizes the regime) is much more mixed. On one hand, the Russian middle class appears to largely exhibit homophobic attitudes characteristic of the traditional values campaign. Sleptcov (2017) and Edinborg (2018) find that the government's explicit political homophobia bolster regime support (Edenborg, 2018; Sleptcov, 2017). However, in terms of women's rights, Nevaeva, Andreeva, and Drozhashchikh write that the traditionalist ideal of heteronormative marriage is increasingly uncommon in Russia (Andreeva, Drozhashchikh and Nelaeva, 2021). Gradskova finds that organizations promoting women's rights, family planning, and LGBTQ+ rights had support among Russians prior to the post-2012 traditional values campaign (Gradskova, 2020). Thus, the degree to which the Putin regime draws support from middle class Russians via gender/sexuality rhetoric and policy is somewhat unclear.

Recently, analysis by Johnson et al. (2021) of Putin's most popular speeches reveal that his post-2012 rhetoric towards women's rights (and likely also towards LGBTQ+ rights, though this is not tested) has shifted to echo popular opinion among middle class Russians who are still largely influenced by Soviet ideals (Johnson et al., 2021). Putin articulates neo-Soviet, moderately conservative, and pseudo-"progressive" attitudes towards women's rights to middle class audiences, while delivering more-extreme conservative rhetoric (and policy) in less visible settings to appease hard-line conservative Russians (Johnson et al., 2021; Sperling et al., 2022). This suggests that Putin is a "weak strongman," balancing benefits across multiple constituencies to maintain power (Fyre, 2021). Table 1 presents neo-Soviet versus hard-line conservative attitudes towards gender and sexuality adapted from Johnson et al. (2021) and Sperling et al. (2022).

TABLE 1 ABOUT HERE

I aggregate disparate groups of adherents to more-extreme conservative gender and sexuality ideology in the hard-line conservative column. This is useful because it allows for a binary distinction between Russians whose beliefs are reflected by the Putin regime's extreme rhetoric and policy and those who are not.

Quantifying the Efficacy of Putin's Gender/Sexuality Rhetoric and Policy

Existing scholarship suggests that sexual/gender politics may be an effective tool of regime legitimation in Russia though this has not been demonstrated using multivariate statistical analysis. As outlined above, previous literature suggests that middle class Russians do not strictly adhere to traditional values outlined in the Putin regime's post-2012 campaign. The Putin regime therefore generates support among the Russian middle class by matching popular neo-Soviet gender/sexuality attitudes. Such attitudes include general notions of homophobia and moderately conservative/pseudo-"progressive" attitudes towards women's rights.

Hypotheses

The following hypotheses, suggested by prior research, are specifically tested:

H1: Neo-Soviet sentiment towards the LGBTQ+ community will be positively associated with regime support among the Russian middle class.

H2: Neo-Soviet attitudes towards women's rights will be positively associated with regime support among the Russian middle class.

H3: Hard-line conservative attitudes towards the LGBTQ+ community and women's rights will not be associated with regime support among the Russian middle class.

Cross-sectional data from Wave 7 of the World Values Survey (WVS) allow me to test the above hypotheses (Haerpfer et al., 2020). Unfortunately, a direct measure of regime support (i.e. "do you support president Putin?") is not available in social survey data such as the WVS. Instead, confidence in government is used as a proxy for regime support. I select Wave 7 of the WVS because of its relative recency and the high quality/relevancy of its questions pertaining to gender/sexuality - the latter of which makes it a favorable alternative to, for example, the Eurpoean Social Survey.

The WVS is a cross-national survey that has been administered every five years since 1981. Wave 7 data was collected in Russia in 2017. Interviews were conducted face-to-face at each respondent's place of residence. The data is weighted by demographic variables such as country, age, and sex to ensure that the final sample is representative of the population.[7]

[7]Documentation available here: https://www.worldvaluessurvey.org/WVSDocumentationWV7.jsp.

Dependent Variables

The dependent variable used in this study is an ordinal measure of confidence in government. Government confidence is operationalized in the WVS by asking "how much confidence [do] you have in... government?" Responses are coded on a scale from 1 for "none at all" to 4 for "a great deal." I choose government confidence as the proxy for regime support because, though it measures confidence in the government broadly, President Putin is such a defining figure of the Russian government that confidence in government and confidence in Putin are likely strongly positively correlated (though a lack of the former variable makes this untestable).

Independent Variables

The independent variables of interest measure attitudes consistent with neo-Soviet and hard-line conservative attitudes towards gender and sexuality. Those measuring **neo-Soviet attitudes** are:

1. General homophobia
2. The importance of women's rights
3. The importance of women bearing children

Those measuring **hard-line conservative attitudes** are:

1. Homosexual parenting
2. Overt sexism
3. The justifiability of abortion
4. The justifiability of divorce
5. The justifiability of beating one's wife

As noted above, homophobia is operationalized through two separate measures. General homophobia is operationalized as attitudes towards the justifiability of being homosexual. General homophobia is coded from 1 (low) to 10 (high). The other measure of homophobia I utilize pertains to the statement: "[h]omosexual couples are as good parents as other couples." It is coded 1 for strongly agree, 2 for agree, 3 for neither agree nor disagree, 4 for disagree, and 5 for strongly disagree. Thus, higher scores again indicate greater homophobia.

Attitudes towards women's rights are operationalized through several measures. I first create an index of overt sexism by adding responses to the following statements coded 1 for strongly disagree to 4 for strongly agree:

1. "On the whole, men make better political leaders than women do."
2. "A university education is more important for a boy than for a girl."
3. "On the whole, men make better business executives than women do."

Thus my sexism index ranges from 3 (low sexism) to 12 (high sexism). The Cronbach's alpha for my sexism index is 0.7093, indicating moderate to high internal consistency.

I also use several distinct questions to measure attitudes towards women's rights. Questions with responses coded low to high on a scale from 1-10 are: the importance of women's rights, the justifiability of abortion, the justifiability of divorce, and the justifiability of beating one's wife. The importance of bearing children is coded from low to high on a scale of 1-5.

Though I simultaneously regress several seemingly related measures of attitudes towards gender and sexuality on confidence in government, my models do not suffer from multicollinearity. Table 2 below displays a correlation matrix of measures of attitudes towards gender/sexuality. The highest correlation coefficient is negative 0.499 and the second highest is negative 0.2159, thus illustrating a lack of multicollinearity.

TABLE 2 ABOUT HERE

The inclusion these eight measures of attitudes towards gender/sexuality allows me to test the extent to which neo-Soviet vs. hard-line conservative attitudes are associated with support for the Putin regime.

The models presented in this study also include a number of independent controls. These are age, ethnicity, educational attainment, and sex. Age is measured in actual years. For ethnicity, I utilize a dummy variable coded 0 for ethnic Russian respondents and 1 for non-ethnic Russian respondents. Education is an ordinal variable where responses are coded low to high where 1 is no formal education and 9 is possessing a doctoral degree. For sex, responses are coded 0 for male and 1 for female.[8,9]

[8] I recode homophobia, overt sexism, and sex. See Appendix A for verbatim WVS questions used in the study.

[9] I do not control for party in each model because, for example, government support and attitudes towards gender and sexuality both have positive effects on a person's membership in United Russia (Putin's political party). Thus, controlling for United Russia membership opens up a backdoor path, confounding the relationship between independent variables of interest and government confidence.

Socioeconomic status is coded 1 for low, 2 for middle, and 3 for high in the WVS. I filter out respondents at the low and high tiers to capture Russia's middle class alone in each of my models.

The spacing across categories in each ordinal independent variable I include in my models are plausibly even. I therefore treat such variables as continuous, as recommended by Pasta and Williams (Pasta, 2009; Williams, 2020).

The unit of analysis in this study is the individual. A total of 1,083 respondents are included in the base model below. Subsequent models include fewer respondents due to missing data on added independent variables.

Model Specification and Marginal Effects

This paper employs ordered probit regression because its dependent variables are ordinal. The ordered probit regression model that this paper follows the general specification presented in equation (1):

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}(y_i = h \mid \boldsymbol{x}_i) =& I[h=1]\Big(\Phi(\kappa_1 - \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta})\Big) \\ &+ I[2 \leq h \leq 3]\Big(\Phi(\kappa_{h-1} - \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta}) - \Phi(\kappa_h - \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta})\Big) \\ &+ I[h=4]\Big(1 - \Phi(\kappa_3 - \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta})\Big)\end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

In equation (1), the subscript i represents an entry in the dataset. Each y_i takes on a category h which has values between 1 and 4 representing low to high confidence in government. As such, $\mathbb{P}(y_i = h \mid \boldsymbol{x}_i)$ represents the probability that y_i takes on the value $h \in \{1, 2, 3, 4\}$ given $\boldsymbol{x}_i$. Each $\boldsymbol{x}_i$ is a $k+1 \times 1$ vector containing 1 and values for each independent variable. $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ is a $k+1 \times 1$ vector containing the intercept and coefficients for each independent variable. The constants $\kappa_1, \ldots, \kappa_3 \in \mathbb{R}$ represent the thresholds at which the y_i's categorization theoretically changes to $1, \ldots, 4$ based on the underlying linear model: $y_i^* = \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta} + \varepsilon_i$, where $\varepsilon_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$.

Ordered probit coefficients are not interpretable. Therefore, in addition to ordered probit tables, this paper also reports the marginal effect of significant variables on the probability that a respondent falls into a specific category of the dependent variable. More specifically, this paper examines the derivative of $\mathbb{P}(y_i = h \mid \boldsymbol{x}_i)$ with respect to the j-th independent variable of interest and averages over all respondents in the dataset. This implicitly holds all other variables in the model constant. The result of the derivation to compute the average

marginal effects (using the chain rule) is given in equation (2) below:

$$\frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\frac{\partial}{\partial x_j}\Big[\mathbb{P}\big(y_i = h \mid \boldsymbol{x}_i\big)\Big] = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\beta_j\Big[\phi(\kappa_{h-1} - \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta}) - \phi(\kappa_h - \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta})\Big] \tag{2}$$

In equation (2), N is the number of entries in the dataset and x_j is the j-th independent variable of interest.[10] Average marginal effects are hereby referred to as marginal effects to be concise.

The marginal effects presented examine the average change in probability a respondent falls into a category for every one point increase in an independent variable. I also report the marginal probability that a respondent falls into a category given a certain independent variable that is held constant. Marginal probabilities are computed as presented in equation (3) below:

$$\frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\mathbb{P}\big(y_i = h \mid \boldsymbol{x}_i = (1, x_{i_1}, \ldots, x_{i_j} = c, \ldots, x_{i_k})\big) \tag{3}$$

In equation (3), the model contains k independent variables and c represents the constant at which the j-th independent variable of interest is being held.

Empirical Results

A series of ordered probit models demonstrate the extent to which homophobia and attitudes towards women's rights influence regime support.[11]

Table 3 displays four ordered probit models predicting confidence in government.

TABLE 3 ABOUT HERE

The first model uses control variables alone. Age is a significant positive predictor of confidence in government at the $p < .01$ level. The remaining control variables are not significant.

The model presented in column 2 uses measures of homophobia as independent variables. General homophobia is significant at the $p < .01$ level, while homosexual parenting is not significant.

[10] I compute the average marginal effect (as opposed to the marginal effect at the average) because it allows me to estimate the average effect in the population (as opposed to the effect for the average respondent). Hanmer and Kalkan show that this approach is advantageous because using observed-values to compute average marginal effects "does a better job associating the theoretical framework and data-collection activities with the properties of limited dependent variable models" than marginal effect at the average approaches that compute a typically unobserved value with which to evaluate marginal effects (Hanmer and Kalkan, 2013).

[11] Replicable code available here: https://github.com/nathanenglehart/englehart-2023.git.

The model presented in column 3 uses measures of attitudes towards women's rights as independent variables. The importance of women's rights is significant at the $p < .001$ level and the importance of bearing children is significant at the $p < .05$ level. The justifiability of abortion, divorce, and beating one's wife are not significant.

In the final model, the importance of bearing children remains significant at the $p < .05$ level. The significance of homophobia and the importance of women's rights decreases to the $p < .05$ and $p < .01$ levels, respectively. Homosexual parenting, overt sexism, the justifiability of aborton, the justifiability of divorce, and the justifiability of beating one's wife are not significant predictors across models 2, 3, and 4.

Table 4 reports the marginal effects of the significant variables of interest based on the results in Table 3 column 4.

TABLE 4 ABOUT HERE

Among gender and sexuality attitudes considered in the final model, the importance of bearing children is the strongest predictor of regime support, posting the highest magnitude across marginal effects. Estimation results suggest that for every one unit increase in the importance of bearing children, the probability that a respondent's confidence in government is "none at all" decreases by 2.11%; "not very much" decreases by 1.09%; "quite a lot" increases by 1.79%; and "a great deal" increases by 1.41%.

Additionally, estimation results suggests that for every one unit increase in homophobia, the probability that a respondent's confidence in government is "none at all" decreases by 0.959%; "not very much" decreases by 0.500%; "quite a lot" increases by 0.817%; and "a great deal" increases by 0.641%. For every one unit increase in the importance of women's rights, the probability that a respondent's confidence in government is "none at all" decreases by 1.32%; "not very much" decreases by 0.690%; "quite a lot" increases by 1.13%; and "a great deal" increases by 0.885%.

Figure 1 displays a visualization of the aforementioned significant marginal effects.

FIGURE 1 ABOUT HERE

Marginal probabilities of homophobia, the importance of women's rights, and the importance of bearing children are reported in Figure 2. The overall marginal effects of homophobia, the importance of women's rights, and justifiability of abortion are not strong enough to flip any probabilities.

FIGURE 2 ABOUT HERE

The overall marginal effect of importance of bearing children flips the probability of respondent's reporting their confidence in government is "a great deal" to being greater than "none at all."

Putin's Neo-Soviet versus Hard-line Conservative Gender/Sexuality Rhetoric and Policy in Middle Class Russia

As outlined above, previous literature finds that Putin regime echos middle class neo-Soviet attitudes to attempt to garner support from the middle class which does not entirely buy into his traditional values rhetoric. I find that this strategy is successful in fostering positive associations between such attitudes and the government. In line with my hypotheses, neo-Soviet attitudes (homophobia, the importance of women's rights, and the importance of bearing children) were all positive predictors of government confidence. At the same time, the Putin regime's hard-line conservative policy and rhetoric does not generate regime support among middle class Russians. Hard-line conservative attitudes (gay parenting, overt sexism, the justifiability of abortion, the justifiability of divorce, and the justifiability of beating one's wife) were not predictors of government confidence.

These results serve as a quantitative confirmation of the efficacy of the post-2012 gender and sexuality strategy Johnson et al. (2021) identifies (Johnson et al., 2021). It extends the study by demonstrating that Soviet-style popular opinion about the LGBTQ+ community (homophobia, but not specific hatred towards homosexuality in "defense of the Russian family/morals") is associated with regime support.

The marginal effects in this study are relatively small. For instance, recall that the marginal effects of homophobia and the importance of women's rights were not strong enough to flip any probabilities. At the same time, Bluhm and Brand find that the importance of "traditional values" is debated within the elite (Brand and Bluhm, 2018). The Putin regime nevertheless increasingly takes more-conservative positions on gender/sexuality as it becomes more authoritarian (Gradskova, 2020). This begs the question, who is the regime *really* trying to please by escalating hard-line conservative rhetoric and policy?

I propose that the regime may seek to please a relatively small group of hard-line conservative Russians that contains a great deal of disproportionately influential elites - many of whom have military connections. For instance, billionaire banker/media executive, Konstanin Malofeev, who has financed separatism in Ukraine, has suggested that women should not work and focus on childbearing.

> "Are there many happy women who have made a career? When the Lord gave the commandment to Adam and Eve, he told Adam to earn his bread by the sweat of his

> brow, and to the women - to give birth to his children in pain" (UCMC, 2023*a*).

Ramzan Kadyrov, head of the Chechen Republic and colonel in the Russian military with a powerful private militia has stated his belief in the justifiability of domestic violence.

> "[A] woman that has married, given birth to children, must know her place. She can be scolded, she can also be beaten, as a mother beats her children" (UCMC, 2023*b*).

Furthermore, under the leadership of Kadyrov, LGBTQ+ rights have been trampled upon in Chechnya. Following systematic purges of LGBTQ+ Chechens in 2017, Kadyrov denied their occurrence in an interview on HBO stating that "[w]e don't have those kinds of people here. We don't have any gays. If there are any, take them to Canada" (Taylor, 2017).

Malofeev and Kadyrov's views on gender/sexuality and notable political power may imply that the Putin regime's increasingly hard-line gender/sexuality policy and rhetoric is meant to appease traditionalism and ultra-conservatism among certain especially influential elites. Such policy and rhetoric is *not* aimed at (or is ineffective in) garnering support from Russia's middle class - though elite demands likely include campaigns to sway popular opinion. The results of my study therefore encourage future analyses of the influence of elite demands on the Putin regime's gender/sexuality rhetoric and policy.

Notes on Study Limitations

The models in this article are subject to some limitations. Confidence in government does not directly capture support for the Putin regime, which would make a preferable regressand (though it is not available in social surveys such as the WVS).

Social desirability bias may plausibly confound the measurement of certain variables. This problem may be especially pronounced in questions such as the importance of women's rights and justifiability of beating one's wife, in which respondents may feel pressure to feign pseudo-"progressive" sentiment. This problem likely *does not* apply to attitudes towards the LGBTQ+ community given widespread/accepted homophobic attitudes in Russia.

Social desirability bias is also unlikely to affect measurement of confidence in government. Numerous studies have found that Russian citizens are unlikely to engage in self-censorship or feign positive attitudes towards the regime (Rose, 2007; Shen and Truex, 2021; Wyman, 1997). Pro-regime response bias is unlikely to confound the results of this study.

Implications and Future Research

Distinct gender politics emerged during the post-Soviet period fed by social displacement. Upon taking power, Vladimir Putin co-opted these gender politics by attaching himself to the *muzhik* male ideal. Following the 2011/2012 protest movement and the Pussy Riot trial, Putin took a conservative shift - especially towards gender/sexuality rhetoric and policy.

I hypothesized that (1) general homophobic sentiment and (2) moderately-conservative and pseudo-"progressive" attitudes towards women's rights would be positive, significant predictors of regime support. I also hypothesized that (3) hard-line conservative sentiment towards gender and sexuality would not be predictors of regime support. Each of these hypotheses was supported.

Middle class Russians' neo-Soviet gender/sexuality ideology is being effectively catered to by the regime according to the results above. Most central to these demands being met are: anti-LGBTQ+ attitudes and support for moderately conservative/"pseudo"-progressive attitudes towards gender.

Hard-line conservative gender/sexuality attitudes are not associated with regime support across models. This suggests that more conservative elements of the regime's gender/sexuality strategy, such as the decriminalization of domestic violence, are meant to please elites (most likely hard-line conservative subset of influential elites) more so than middle class Russians. Future research on gender/sexuality rhetoric and policy as a regime legitimation technique in Russia should further explore this likelihood and its machinations.

This study demonstrates the usefulness of social survey data in examining questions of gender, sexuality, and politics in Russia and similar countries. Future studies may benefit from related research designs, using social survey data and binary or ordered choice regressions models to examine associations between attitudes towards gender/sexuality and regime support.

Finally, the field of text as data may be useful methodology in future research. For instance, speech corpora - such as Putin's speeches collected by Johnson et al. (2021) or similar collections - could be analyzed using supervised classification methods and/or topic models to uncover latent patterns and associations. Filtering a speech corpus by audience (e.g. elite vs. mass) may reveal fluctuations in regime priorities and outreach.

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Tables

Table 1: Gender and Sexuality Attitudes

	Neo-Soviet	**Hard-line Conservative**
LGBTQ+	Adherents hold stereotypical homophobic views towards Russia's LGBTQ+ community. They believe that discriminatory policy is not necessary, but neither is protective policy.	Hard-line conservative adherents advocate for explicitly discriminatory policy towards LGBTQ+ Russians who they view with disgust. The more-extreme end of this group believes in vigilante violence against the LGBTQ+ community.
Women's Rights	Neo-Soviet adherents believe that women are primarily mothers. While it is important for women to have children, women are also fully capable workers (as long as their profession does not interfere with their womanliness).	Hard-line conservative adherents not only emphasize the importance of childbearing, but oppose abortion. More-extreme adherents oppose divorce and premarital sex, while supporting policy including the decriminalization of domestic violence.

Adapted from Johnson et al. (2021) and Sperling et al. (2022).

Table 2: Correlation Matrix of Measures of Attitudes Towards Gender/Sexuality

	sexism	abortion	beat_wife	bear_child	women_rights	homoph.	homo_par	divorce
sexism	1.0000							
abortion	-0.499*	1.0000						
beat_wife	0.1139***	0.1171***	1.0000					
bear_child	0.0434	-0.0762**	-0.0018	1.0000				
women_rights	-0.1339***	0.1080***	-0.1282***	0.0140	1.0000			
homoph.	0.0385	-0.2159***	-0.0953***	0.0559*	0.0101	1.0000		
homo_par	0.0622	0.0313	0.1308*	-0.0256*	-0.1214***	-0.0680***	1.0000	
divorce	-0.0414	0.5983***	0.0795**	-0.1117***	0.1217***	-0.2083***	-0.0039	1.0000

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 3: Modeling Gov. Conf. as a Function of Measures of Attitudes Towards Gender/Sexuality

	(1) gov_satisfaction	(2) gov_satisfaction	(3) gov_satisfaction	(4) gov_satisfaction
Controls				
1.female	0.0893	0.0415	0.108	0.0484
	(1.36)	(0.59)	(1.45)	(0.62)
age	0.00526**	0.00581*	0.00266	0.00365
	(2.58)	(2.57)	(1.17)	(1.49)
educ	-0.0221	-0.0263	-0.00993	-0.0146
	(-1.16)	(-1.29)	(-0.47)	(-0.65)
1.ethnic_minority	-0.100	-0.152	-0.129	-0.133
	(-1.16)	(-1.57)	(-1.24)	(-1.21)
Neo-Soviet				
gen_homophobia		0.0488**		0.0378*
		(3.25)		(2.05)
women_rights			0.0715***	0.0522**
			(4.03)	(2.73)
bearing_children			0.0729*	0.0808*
			(2.26)	(2.41)
Hard-line Cons.				
homo_parents		0.0228		0.0143
		(0.69)		(0.38)
sexism			0.0142	-0.0140
			(0.73)	(-0.68)
abortion			-0.000585	-0.0113
			(-0.04)	(-0.68)
divorce			-0.0307	-0.0278
			(-1.88)	(-1.60)
beat_wife			-0.0197	-0.00447
			(-1.11)	(-0.22)
Constants				
cut1	-0.894***	-0.456*	-0.249	-0.336
	(-5.62)	(-2.08)	(-0.74)	(-0.91)
cut2	-0.0375	0.438*	0.613	0.570
	(-0.24)	(1.98)	(1.84)	(1.55)
cut3	1.212***	1.779***	1.906***	1.937***
	(7.57)	(7.85)	(5.70)	(5.22)
N	1083	951	909	830
pseudo R^2	0.004	0.013	0.017	0.022

t statistics in parentheses

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 4: Marginal Effects of **Neo-Soviet Attitudes** Towards Gender/Sexuality on Gov. Conf.

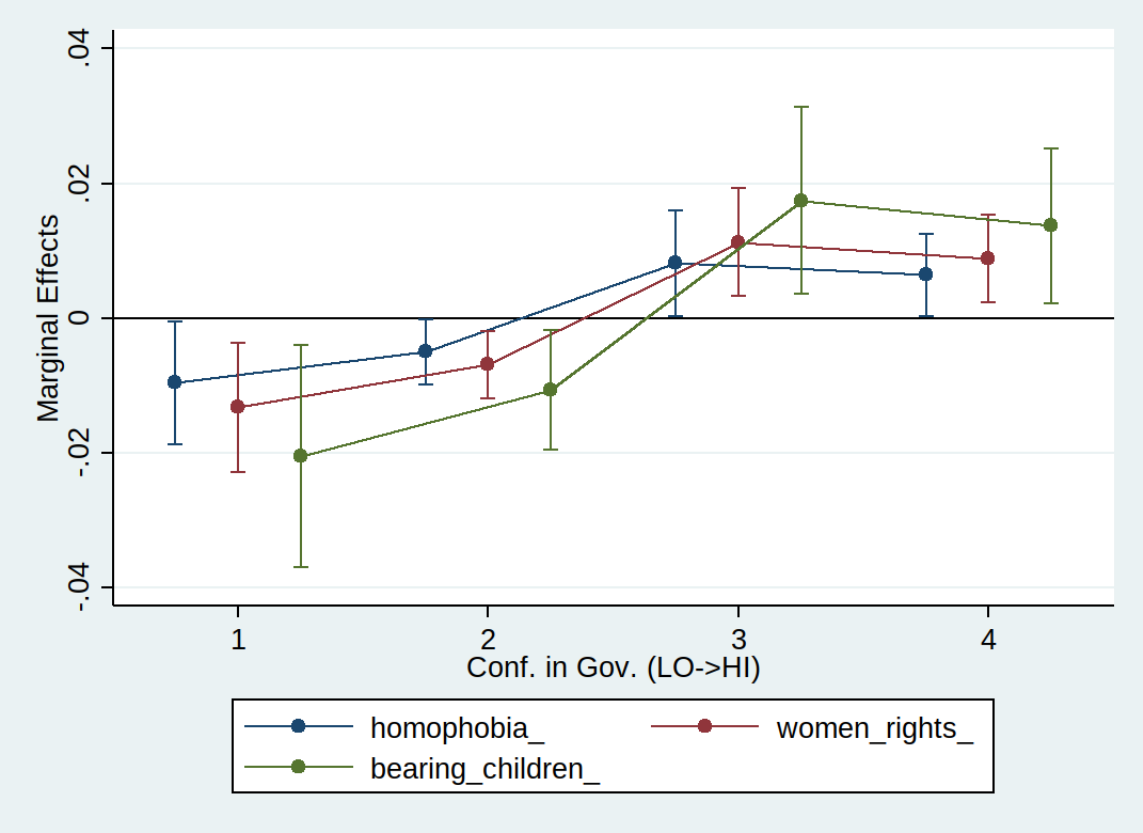
	(1)	(2)	(3)
gen_homophobia			
(1) "none at all"	-0.0123**		-0.00959*
	(-3.26)		(-2.06)
(2) "not very much"	-0.00672**		-0.00500*
	(-3.18)		(-2.04)
(3) "quite a lot"	0.0104**		0.00817*
	(3.26)		(2.05)
(4) "a great deal"	0.00865**		0.00641*
	(3.18)		(2.05)
bearing_children			
(1) "none at all"		-0.0185*	-0.0205*
		(-2.28)	(-2.43)
(2) "not very much"		-0.00980*	-0.0107*
		(-2.21)	(-2.35)
(3) "quite a lot"		0.0141*	0.0175*
		(2.29)	(2.46)
(4) "a great deal"		0.0142*	0.0137*
		(2.21)	(2.33)
women_rights			
(1) "none at all"		-0.0181***	-0.0132**
		(-4.00)	(-2.71)
(2) "not very much"		-0.00961***	-0.00690**
		(-3.98)	(-2.71)
(3) "quite a lot"		0.0138***	0.0113**
		(4.01)	(2.74)
(4) "a great deal"		0.0139***	0.00885**
		(3.93)	(2.66)
N	951	909	830

t statistics in parentheses

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

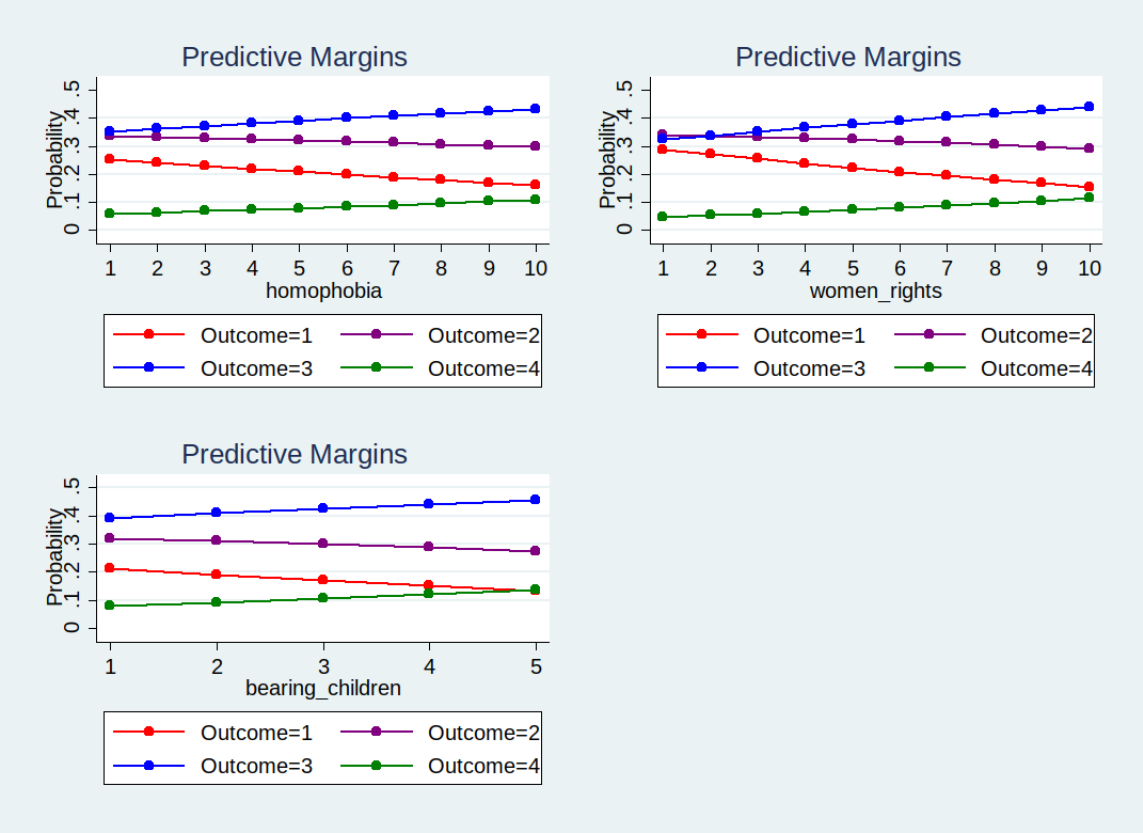
Figures

Figure 1: Marginal Probabilities of Gov. Conf.



Predictive margins computed using the model from column 4 of Table 3/column 3 of Table 4.

Figure 2: Marginal Effects of Sig. Attitudes on Gov. Conf.



Marginal effects from column 3 of Table 4.

A Appendix

A.I Operationalization Details

This appendix supplies verbatim World Values Survey (WVS) questions used across ordered probit regression models. Each variable is listed as it is referred to in the paper. The verbatim question is provided beneath and details on recoding are provided if applicable.

1. Confidence in Government

The WVS administers Questions Q64-Q89 with the following:

> "I am going to name a number of organizations. For each one, could you tell me how much confidence you have in them: is it a great deal of confidence, quite a lot of confidence, not very much confidence, or none at all?"

Question Q71 lists "[t]he government." Table A.1 below presents the original coding of responses and my subsequent recoding.

Table A.1: Confidence in Government Coding

Code	Original	Recode
1	A great deal	None at all
2	Quite a lot	Not very much
3	Not very much	Quite a lot
4	None at all	A great deal

2. Female

Question Q260 records the respondent's sex on the WVS. Table A.2 below presents the original coding of responses and my subsequent recoding.

Table A.2: Female Coding

Code	Original	Recode
0	-	Male
1	Male	Female
2	Female	-

3. Age

Question Q262 asks respondents: "This means you are _____ years old" as a follow up to Q261 which asks respondents "Can you tell me your year of birth, please?" I utilize Q262 to measure age in actual years.

4. Education

Questions Q275-278 asks respondents: "What is the highest education level that you, your spouse, your mother and father have attained?" Q275 records respondents educational level. Table A.3 below presents the original coding of responses which I do not recode.

Table A.3: Education Coding

Code	**Original**
0	Early childhood education / no education
1	Primary education
2	Lower secondary education
3	Upper secondary education
4	Post-secondary education
5	Short-cycle tertiary education
6	Bachelor or equivalent
7	Master or equivalent
8	Doctoral or equivalent

5. Ethnic Minority

Question Q290 asks for the "Respondents ethnic group." The WVS notes that available responses are "Modif[ied]... for... [each] country/society." Russia's available responses are presented in Table A.4 below. Table A.4 also includes original coding and recoding. As noted in the Independent Variables section, I create a dummy for whether a respondent is an ethnic minority or not.

Table A.4: Ethnicity Coding

Code	**Original**	**Recode**
Russian	643001	0
Tatar	643002	1
Ukrainian	643003	1
German	643007	1
Georgian	643015	1
Armenian	643016	1
Moldovan	643020	1
Italian	643023	1
Kazakh	643035	1
Azeri	643036	1
North-East Asian	643037	1
Tajik	643040	1
Kyrgyz	643053	1
Uzbek	643080	1
Iranian & Central Asian	643097	1
Other	643999	1

6. General Homophobia

Questions Q177-Q195 ask respondents to:

> "Please tell me for each of the following actions whether you think it can always be justified, never be justified, or something in between, using this card."

Q182 asks respondents their opinion on "Homosexuality." Responses are coded 1 for never justifiable to 10 for always justifiable. I recode this variable such that 1 becomes always justifiable and 10 is never justifiable. Thus, for every one unit increase in this variable, respondents report higher degrees of homophobia.

7. Quality of Homosexual Parents

Questions Q33-Q41 asks respondents: "How would you feel about the following statements? Do you agree or disagree with them?" Question Q36 lists "Homosexual couples are as good parents as other couples." Table A.4 below presents the original coding of responses. I do not recode this question.

Table A.5: Quality of Homosexual Parents Coding

Code	Original
1	Agree strongly
2	Agree
3	Neither agree nor disagree
4	Disagree
5	Disagree strongly

8. Overt Sexism

Overt sexism is an index variable created from questions Q29, Q30, and Q31. These three questions first ask:

> "For each of the following statements I read out, can you tell me how strongly you agree or disagree with each. Do you strongly agree, agree, disagree, or strongly disagree?"

Table A.5 below presents the original coding of responses and my subsequent recoding.

Table A.6: Overt Sexism Index Coding

Code	Original	Recode
1	Agree strongly	Disagree strongly
2	Agree	Disagree
3	Disagree	Agree
4	Disagree strongly	Agree strongly

Questions Q29-Q31 are presented below:

1. Q29: "On the whole, men make better political leaders than women do."
2. Q30: "A university education is more important for a boy than a girl."
3. Q31: "On the whole, men make better business executives than women do."

9. Importance of Women's Rights

Questions Q241-Q249 asks respondents:

> "Many things are desirable, but not all of them are essential characteristics of democracy. Please tell me for each of the following things how essential you think it is as a characteristic of democracy. Use this scale where 1 means 'not at all an essential characteristic of democracy' and 10 means it definitely is 'an essential characteristic of democracy'."

Question 249 specifically asks respondents to apply this prompt to the statement: "Women have the same rights as men." I do not recode this question.

10. Importance of Bearing Children

Questions Q33-Q41 ask respondents: "How would you feel about the following statements? Do you agree or disagree with them?" Question Q37 lists "It is a duty towards society to have children." Table A.6 below presents the original coding of responses and my subsequent recoding.

Table A.7: Quality of Homosexual Parents Coding

Code	Original	Recode
1	Agree strongly	Disagree strongly
2	Agree	Disagree
3	Neither agree nor disagree	Neither agree nor disagree
4	Disagree	Agree
5	Disagree strongly	Agree strongly

11. Justifiability of Abortion

Questions Q177-Q195 ask respondents to:

> "Please tell me for each of the following actions whether you think it can always be justified, never be justified, or something in between, using this card."

Q184 asks respondents their opinion on "Abortion." Responses are coded 1 for never justifiable to 10 for always justifiable. I do not recode this variable.

12. Justifiability of Beating One's Wife

Questions Q177-Q195 ask respondents to:

> "Please tell me for each of the following actions whether you think it can always be justified, never be justified, or something in between, using this card."

Q189 asks respondents their opinion on if it is justifiable "For a mean to beat his wife." Responses are coded 1 for never justifiable to 10 for always justifiable. I do not recode this variable.

13. Justifiability of Divorce

Questions Q177-Q195 ask respondents to:

> "Please tell me for each of the following actions whether you think it can always be justified, never be justified, or something in between, using this card."

Q183 asks respondents their opinion on "Divorce." Responses are coded 1 for never justifiable to 10 for always justifiable. I do not recode this variable.